REVIEW

# Do school smartphone bans improve grades and mental health?

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SUMMARY

**School phone restrictions may help some pupils, but dependable improvements in grades or mental health remain uncertain. Confidence in these outcomes is low: studies compare different policies and measure different kinds of success.**

## 01 Less school-time use does not establish better wellbeing

- Restrictive English schools had lower school-time phone use than permissive schools, with an adjusted difference of **−0.67 hours daily**; this was an observational association.[1]
- Overall weekday and weekend phone use showed no detectable difference between policy groups.[1]
- A rapid review reported a small pooled benefit across academic and social outcomes, but explicitly cautioned that academic evidence was limited.[2]
- Figure 1 contrasts phone access under two school-policy settings.

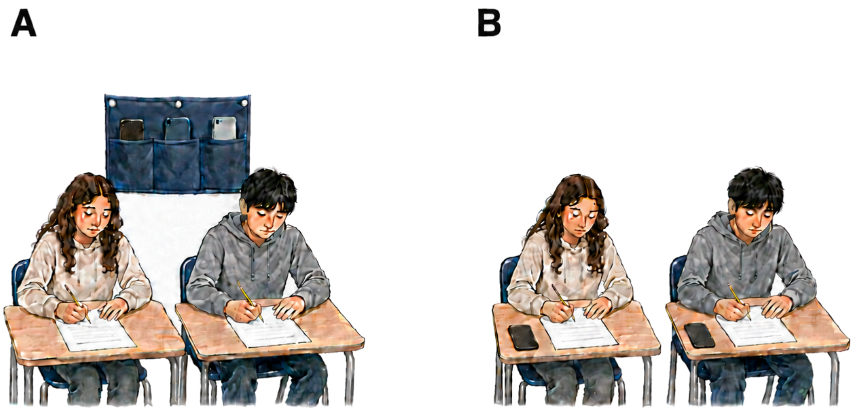


**Figure 1. School phone access differs.** The English observational study compared restrictive and permissive schools and assessed pupil wellbeing.[1] A related qualitative study examined both policy types.[3] Panel A shows stored phones; Panel B shows phones accessible on desks. Pupils and questionnaires are schematic; their number and expressions encode no sample size or wellbeing difference.

## 02 Academic gains depend on the outcome and setting

- Test-score gains followed regional bans in Galicia, Spain; the authors expressed the maths gains as **0.6–0.8 years of learning**.[4]
- Academic engagement showed no detectable advantage in a preregistered South Australian comparison after one month.[5]
- The two findings therefore answer different questions: a short engagement assessment cannot settle whether examination grades improve over years.

## 03 Mental-health findings include benefits and null results

- Lower psychological distress was associated with bans in a secondary South Australian analysis; its abstract describes the difference as small.[6]
- English schools with restrictive policies showed no evidence of better mental wellbeing.[1]
- Dutch schools with full bans showed no detectable wellbeing or bullying advantage over classroom-only bans.[7]

- Anxiety increased during a Hungarian mobile-free day; its brief, within-school design limits conclusions about permanent policies.[8]
- Figure 2 compares the English study's adjusted use and well-being differences with their uncertainty.

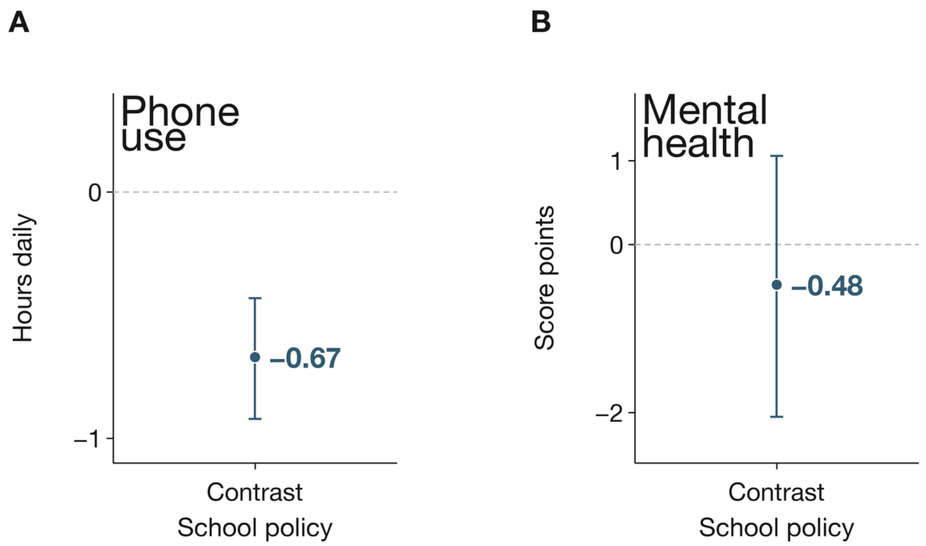


**Figure 2. Less school-time use did not establish better wellbeing.** Panel A: adjusted phone-use difference −0.67 hours daily, with 95% confidence interval −0.92 to −0.43.[1] Panel B: adjusted wellbeing-score difference −0.48 points, with 95% confidence interval −2.05 to 1.06.[1] Points contrast restrictive minus permissive schools; attached whiskers show the intervals. Vertical units differ and zero means no difference. The English school-policy comparison was observational.[1] Qualitative follow-up described benefits and drawbacks under both policy types.[3]

| COMPARISON | OUTCOME | FINDING | SOURCE |
|---|---|---|---|
| South Australian ban versus no-ban schools | Academic engagement | Standardized difference 0.03; 95% confidence interval −0.14 to 0.20 | 5 |
| Dutch full versus classroom-only bans | Wellbeing and bullying | No significant differences | 7 |

## 04 A plausible mechanism does not settle policy effectiveness

- Better recall followed phone removal in an undergraduate laboratory task, which did not test school grades or mental health.[9]
- A review linked heavier smartphone use with poorer academic performance, while warning that the underlying associations could not establish causation.[10]
- The recurring pattern is a gap between restricting access and demonstrating lasting benefit. A qualitative SMART Schools follow-up described benefits and drawbacks under both policy types.[3]
- Low confidence leaves room for context-specific benefit; the present comparisons do not establish a reliable policy effect across schools.

**Scope and methods** — Narrative review; OpenAlex and PubMed searches on 4 September 2026 included recent and contrary findings. Peer-reviewed policy comparisons informed conclusions; laboratory and general-use studies supplied context. Five cited papers were read in full and five through abstracts. The Australian analyses and SMART Schools publications were grouped by study family. Review overlap was not treated as independent replication. Crossref screening found no integrity signal on the search date; several publisher notice pages were inaccessible.

## References

10 · VERIFIED VIA CROSSREF

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